

Form & Volume

Making flat shapes feel three-dimensional

A drawing that communicates volume convincingly feels like the objects have real weight and occupy real space. Volume is communicated through perspective, value, and most importantly — how you construct the underlying form.

KEY CONCEPTS

Planes

Every 3D form is made of planes — flat or curved surfaces that face different directions. A cube has 6 planes. A sphere is one continuous curved plane. Identifying planes helps you understand where light will fall and how to shade convincingly.

Contour Lines

Contour lines are lines drawn on the surface of a form that follow its curvature, like latitude lines on a globe. They reveal the 3D nature of a form immediately and are a powerful drawing tool.

Drawing Through

'Drawing through' means drawing the complete form, including the parts you can't see. Draw the back edges of a box, even when they're hidden. This habit builds spatial understanding and catches proportion errors.

Volume vs Outline

Beginners often draw the outline of an object and leave it flat. The shift to volumetric thinking means building the form in 3D first, then defining the outline as a byproduct of the 3D construction.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw a sphere with contour lines showing its curvature in 3 different orientations.
2. Draw a box with all 12 edges visible (draw through). Then erase the hidden lines.
3. Draw a cylinder: draw through, show the far ellipse as a dotted line.

FURTHER READING

■ Draw a Box – Form

<https://drawabox.com/lesson/1>

■ CTRL+Paint – Form

<https://www.ctrlpaint.com/videos/3d-form>